an Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank, whose co-founders included the richest European countries and the Bretton Woods Institutions, leaving the Obama administration diplomatically embarrassed.

These incidents suggest the possibility that at least two of the BRICS – China and Russia – occasionally adopt 'inter-imperial' stances against Western powers, but in a stop-start way that is quite unpredictable. At the same time, however, the underlying BRICS project has much in common with the Western status quo regarding the stabilisation of the financial world, in generating additional capacities of 'lender of last resort' and in stabilising multilateral governance. BRICS still provides a sustained demand for the US dollar, despite monetary turbulence due to Federal Reserve policies; it is distressing but true that Chinese dollar purchases soared to record highs during the first half of 2014, only declining slightly a year later.

Moreover, the BRICS countries promote an extractive, high-carbon economic model which threatens to amplify the catastrophic environmental and social destruction of advanced capitalism. The role of the BRICS in the *de facto* derailing of the Kyoto Protocol to limit climate change is revealing: Russia endorsed the Treaty in 2005 but withdrew in 2012, while in 2009 the other BRICS leaders joined Barack Obama to promote the Copenhagen Accord in behind-the-scenes negotiations. That 2009 deal rejected a mandatory limit on emissions, and at subsequent UN Framework Convention on Climate Change Conferences of the Parties, BRICS countries (including host South Africa in 2011) were among those joining Washington as most resistant to binding emissions cuts and payment of climate debt. By 2011 in South Africa, they had agreed to whittle away the critical notion of 'common but differentiated responsibility' for the crisis, to the detriment of the world's poorest and lowest-emitting countries.

As for Snowden's revelations, the surveillance of citizens seems as severe in the BRICS countries as in the anglophone West, in a style reminiscent of George Orwell's *1984*, reaching even into the South African parliament in February 2015, when journalists' cellphones and Wi-Fi signals were jammed by Pretoria's security apparatus. The BRICS' criminalisation of social movements and the oppression of dissidents are even worse than in the G7. The economic and political domination of the BRICS' less-developed neighbours is a growing concern, leading critics to postulate the incorporation of sub-imperialist BRICS into world capitalism, just as Ruy Mauro Marini wrote regarding the position of Brazil more than 40 years ago.